As mentioned earlier, a separate division to deal with Sikh extremism and its links with Pakistan's ISI had been created at the R&AW by end 1980. Sometime in early 1981**,** Director (R) Suntook asked me to prepare and send proposals to the MEA for the creation of seven R&AW stations in Indian missions (both embassies and consulates) in west Europe and North America (US and Canada). These missions were to be located in areas with a sizeable presence of Sikh immigrants. Suntook said my proposal should specifically mention that we had observed the growing extremist leanings among certain sections of the Sikh diaspora and there was every likelihood that the demand for Khalistan would gain momentum in these areas in the not-too-distant future. In view of that, the R&AW would like to post its officers in those missions to keep a close watch on the developments and to help the Government of India take suitable preventive measures in advance.

While I knew first hand that the Sikh diaspora in North America did not harbour any such sentiments till then, I prepared these one-and-a-half-page proposals, nonetheless, drawing partly on my memory of some fanciful ideas narrated to me by a pro-Khalistan ideologue who, after Operation Blue Star, came out openly in favour of Khalistan. He was soon raised by the R&AW as its source and used as a double agent to gauge the extent of the ISI's involvement in pro-Khalistan activities in Punjab. Later, the senior R&AW officer who was handling that source asked me to facilitate his surrender. Without letting the officer feel that all those years I knew about his source's connection with our department, I politely refused to get involved in a contrived operation.

I thought the proposals for the creation of seven overseas missions to keep a tab on Sikh separatists would not be accepted, on one pretext or the other, by the MEA as many other proposals, even for a single junior-level post, would usually get stuck there for a considerably longer period. To convey the importance of the proposals, I got four of them signed by Joint Director A.K. Verma (later secretary, R&AW). Contrary to my expectations and to my utter delight, all seven proposals were accepted by the MEA rather quickly. I thought I had achieved the impossible.